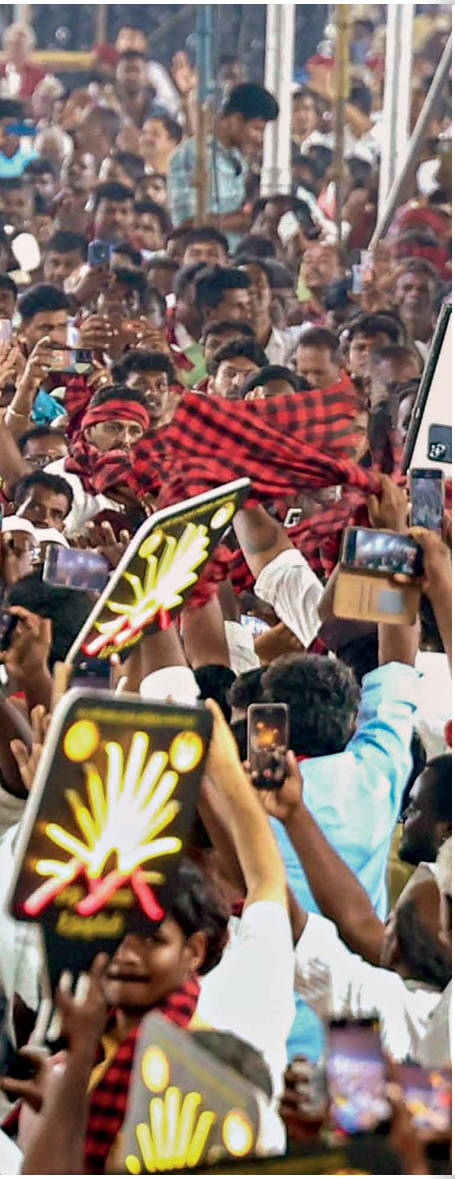


THE INCUMBENT

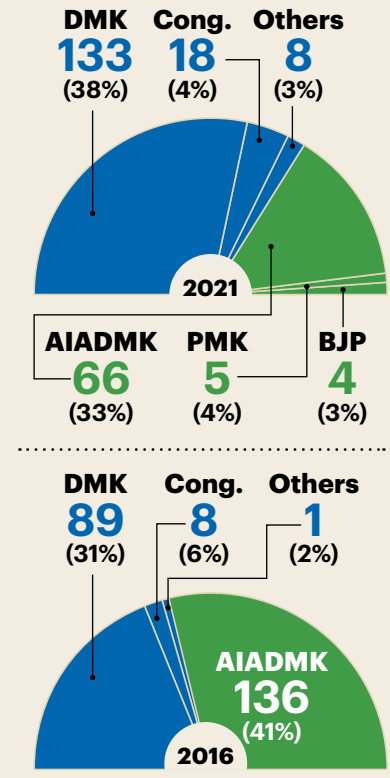
M.K. Stalin, 73, DMK
Chief Minister, Tamil Nadu

KEY STRATEGIES

- Conveying the message on the success of the 'Dravidian Model' in governance—a formulation that combines welfare delivery, social justice and an assertive federal stand—to the voter
- Of the 164 DMK candidates contesting this time, 60-plus are first-time candidates. Three ministers have also been dropped, which is seen as a move to eliminate non-performers
- Coalition with Congress, CPI, CPI(M) and VCK has now added the DMDK and ex-AIADMK CM O. Panneerselvam to the ranks. Has created a diverse regional and social vote base
- Framing the contest as one between Tamil Nadu and Delhi, and spreading the message that the BJP effectively leads the AIADMK-led alliance
- Aggressive focus on Gen Z voter through social media. DMK leaders now participate in non-political, chatty shows; Stalin's gig is called 'Vibe with MKS'

PAST RECORD

Total seats: **234**



(The BJP contested with smaller allies but had zero impact)

DMK-led coalition
AIADMK-led coalition

Numbers denote seats won; vote share in ()

For decades leading up to 2021, Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin was seen as a leader-in-waiting, biding his time under the shadow of his father, the late Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) titan, M. Karunanidhi. The 2026 assembly election, then, marks a distinct and more personal milestone for him and the DMK. The 73-year-old CM has completed his first term, and his bid to secure a second one places Stalin and his record in office under direct scrutiny.

Till 2021, the DMK had spent a decade in the wilderness when the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) ruled the roost. It was also a time of transition: Karunanidhi passed away in 2018, and Stalin inherited not just the party leadership but also a complex set of electoral and organisational challenges. He triumphed over them: the DMK got 133 seats in the 234-member house in 2021; the Secular Progressive Alliance won 159 overall. The AIADMK was reduced to 66 seats.

Five years on, the shift is evident, even if the rhetoric signals continuity. Stalin had enshrined the 'Dravidian model' in governance, a formulation that combines welfare delivery, social justice and an assertive federal stand. The 2026 manifesto reprises this as 'Dravidian Model 2.0', with the emphasis now on scale and reach.

Dravidian Model 2.0

Flagship programmes introduced or expanded since 2021 form the backbone of the DMK's narrative. These include the Kalaignar Magalir Urimai Thogai scheme, which provides direct cash benefit (DBT) transfers to women who head the household; free bus travel for women; the CM's breakfast scheme for schoolchildren; the Pudhumai Penn initiative supporting girls' education; the Naan Mudhalvan programme focused on youth skill development; and a doorstep healthcare initiative named Makkalai Thedi Maruthuvam. These schemes are designed to create a broad coalition of beneficiaries across caste and class lines.

The DMK regime says some 13.1 million women have benefited from the DBT scheme. It also cites a growth rate of 11.2